

NOTRUMP OPENINGS

These 100 Deals are all about hands that are either opened 1NT or 2NT, or perhaps overcalled 1NT or 2NT. Some of them end up being played at a Notrump contract, but others are played with a trump suit.

The proficiency level for the Deals is Intermediate/Advanced, both in the Bidding and Declarer play.

ABOUT THE DEALS

With both hands visible and the opening lead noted you are asked to make a Plan for each Deal. You should think this through just as if you were at the table.

All of the Notrump Plans include a Winner Count and all Suit Plans include a Loser Count.

During the Bidding section you are in the South position. As a result of that some of the Deals would end up with your partner North as the Declarer.

ABOUT THE BIDDING

Normal 4-3-2-1 point count is used, with 1 length point added for any card more than 4 in any suit.

1NT Opening: 15-17 points

2NT Opening: 20-21 points

1NT Overcall: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers in their suit

2NT Overcall over a Weak 2-bid: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers

Stayman convention is used extensively.

Jacoby Transfers are used extensively.

In addition to the standard 2♦ transfer to ♥ and 2♥ transfer to ♠ we also use a 2♠ transfer to 3♣.

The **lebensohl** convention is used when opponents overcall your side's 1NT opening.

Since this is not a standard for many of you, a brief explanation/comment is given when it occurs.

You can go either go through the deals in order, or use the Navigation Bar at left.

Board: 1

Dealer: **North**

Contract: 3♠

Declarer: North

Lead: ♦ J

Board: 2

Dealer: **East**

Contract: 3NT

Declarer: East

Lead: ♦ Q

Board: 3

Dealer: **South**

Contract: 3NT

Declarer: South

Lead: ♥ 5

Board: 4

Dealer: **West**

Contract: 4♠

Declarer: West

Lead: ♥ K

Board 1

North Deals

None Vul

♠ 7
♥ Q J 9 6 3
♦ Q 8 4
♣ K 10 5 3

♠ A 10 2

♥ A 8

♦ A K 7 3

♣ 9 8 6 2



♠ K Q 5

♥ K 10 4

♦ J 10 9 5

♣ J 7 4

♠ J 9 8 6 4 3

♥ 7 5 2

♦ 6 2

♣ A Q

West	North	East	South
	1NT	Pass	2♥
Pass	2♠	Pass	3♠
All Pass			
3♠ by North			
Lead: ♦ J			

you only counted one ♥ loser - that means you MUST ruff a ♥ in your hand.

Win the ♦ lead and play ♥ A and another ♥ before you touch trumps.

After this there is nothing the defense can do to stop you ruffing one ♥ in your hand.

Just suppose for an instant that you had played ♠ A and another.

East would have taken the second ♠, then pulled your last ♠. When the ♣ finesse failed you would make only 8 tricks.

Partner's 2♥ bid is a transfer; you respond 2♠.

Partner now bids 3♠.

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Partner now bids 3♠.

Partner tells you that he has only invitational strength, but has at least 6 ♠s. The ♠s are fine by you, but with only 15 HCP you decide to pass.

North plays 3♠. East leads the ♦ J. UhOh. Maybe you should have bid game.

Loser List: ♠ = ? : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = ?

If the ♠s are 2-2 there will be only one loser in that suit. And maybe the ♣ finesse will work.

Don't get too optimistic too early. If you play ♠ A and another ♠ you could go down. Remember that

Board 2

East Deals

N-S Vul

♠ K Q 8 6 3

♥ 6 2

♦ K 7 3

♣ K 6 2

♠ J 9 5 2

♥ Q J 5

♦ 9 2

♣ 10 9 7 4

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ A 10

♥ K 7 4 3

♦ A 6 5 4

♣ A Q 5

♠ 7 4

♥ A 10 9 8

♦ Q J 10 8

♣ J 8 3

West

North

East

South

2♥

Pass

2♠

Pass

3NT

All Pass

3NT by East

Lead: ♦ Q

With 12 points and a 5-card Major you transfer partner to that Major. You bid 2♥. Partner bids 2♠. Now what do say next?

With 12 points and a 5-card Major you transfer partner to that Major. You bid 2♥. Partner bids 2♠. Now what do say next?

You must insist on game, but since partner could have a doubleton ♠ you do so by bidding 3NT to give him the choice.

He chooses 3NT by passing.

The contract would be 3NT played by West.

East plays 3NT. South leads the ♦ Q. Do you win the first trick or holdup?

Winner List: ♠ = 3 : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 3 :: Total = 8

A holdup wouldn't hurt you since South would retain the lead. But it probably wouldn't help you much either since you do have 2 stoppers in the suit. You obviously need to establish at least one more winner in ♠s so you won't have to depend on the ♥ A being with North. Need it be said that ♥s is the suit you are worried about and North is the Danger hand? Let's say you win the first trick with dummy's ♦ K.

Suppose you play ♠ A, then ♠ K Q. If they split 3-3 you will be sooooo happy because you will make at least 10 tricks. But if North shows out on the third ♠ you will be pretty happy because you can give up a ♠ to South and still make at least 9 tricks. But if South shows out on the third ♠ you could be in deep trouble. You would have to give North the lead to establish an extra ♠ winner, and he might very well lead through your ♥ K.

There is a great safety play to protect against a 4-2 ♠ split. Play a low ♠ from dummy and finesse the ♠ 10. South may win with a doubleton ♠ J but you will still make the contract.

With this layout the safety play finesse actually works and you make an overtrick.

But visualize the ♠ J and ♠ 7 transposed. If you don't make the safety play it is true that the ♠ J will fall. BUT, North will still take the fourth ♠ and when he gets in he will return the ♥ Q.

Board 3

South Deals

None Vul

♠ A 6 2
♥ K J 8 5 2
♦ 9 8
♣ 10 7 3

♠ Q 10 9 8 4

♥ A 4

♦ Q 7 2

♣ 8 6 5

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ 7 5 3
♥ Q 6
♦ J 10 6 4
♣ K J 9 2

♠ K J

♥ 10 9 7 3

♦ A K 5 3

♣ A Q 4

West	North	East	South
			1NT
Pass	2♥	Pass	2♠
Pass	2NT	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by South

Lead: ♥5

out the ♠A the defenders might be able to cash 4 ♥s right away. So the immediate decision is whether you take the ♥A on the first trick or wait until the second.

If West has only 4 ♥s it will make no difference what you do because they will only win 3 ♥ tricks and you will make your contract. So assume that West has a 5-card suit, which means that East has 2 ♥s. West's suit is definitely **NOT** ♥ K Q J 5 2; he would have started with the ♥K, not the ♥5. So you can be sure that East holds either ♥ K x, ♥ Q x or ♥ J x. So what?

So you should play the ♥A immediately. If East puts on his small ♥ then his lone honor will block the suit the next time it is played. But if he unblocks the honor under dummy's ♥A then your ♥ 10 9 7 will be promoted into a second stopper.

If you play low on the first trick East will win the ♥Q and return the ♥6 to dummy's ♥A. When West gains the lead with his ♠A he will cash 3 more ♥ tricks. Down 1.

Play the ♥A on the first trick and East is hog-tied. If he plays low the suit blocks, if he sacrifices his ♥Q then your ♥ 10 9 7 prevents West from running the suit.

Partner's 2♥ is a transfer, so you bid 2♠. Partner now bids 2NT.

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Partner is only inviting, so he must have either 9 or 10 points. And since he chose 2NT as the invitation he must have only 5 ♠s. You will accept the invitation since you have a maximum 1NT opener, and you choose 3NT since you know there is no 8-card ♠ fit.

South plays 3NT. When West leads the ♥5 you have an immediate decision to make.

Winner List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 3 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 5

It is pretty clear that the 4 additional winners you need will be ♠s. The danger is that when you force

Board 4

West Deals

Both Vul

♠ A 10 7 3
♥ 9 7
♦ K Q J
♣ K Q J 7

♠ 5

♥ K Q J 6 5 2

♦ A 6 4

♣ 9 4 3



♠ K 9 8 6
♥ A 10 4
♦ 10 7 5 2
♣ A 2

♠ Q J 4 2

♥ 8 3

♦ 9 8 3

♣ 10 8 6 5

West	North	East	South
1NT	2♥	2NT	Pass
3♣	Pass	3♥	Pass
3♠	Pass	4♠	

All Pass

4♠ by West

Lead: ♥K

stopper in the enemy suit. In any case, partner replies 3♠. Next?

You bid 4♠.

The contract would be 4♠ played by East.

West plays 4♠. North leads the ♥K. Do you take the first trick or not?

Loser List: ♠ = 1/2 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = 3/4

You should not hold up on the ♥ for two reasons. First, South might have a singleton. Second, you might not have a ♥ loser at all (if you can discard both of dummy's ♥ losers on your ♣s.

So win the ♥A and start on trumps by playing ♠A, then ♠K. Uh Oh. South discards a ♥ on the second ♠ so you have two ♠ losers.

Now you will have to be lucky. Leave the two master trumps undrawn and start running the ♣s. Fortunately South has 4 ♣s and you are able to discard both of dummy's ♥ losers. Play a ♦ next and your luck continues when it is North who takes the trick. Since South can't get in to pull your trumps, you cannot be defeated. You play your ♦ winners and ruff a ♥ in dummy. South will get his two trumps at the end.

Imagine what would have happened if you had played a third trump.

South would have taken the two trump tricks, then North would have taken 5 ♥ tricks and the ♦A.

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